NEW NAVIES OF EUROPE



Siege of Sevastopol
The largest naval operation in the early years of steam power was the Anglo-French expedition to the Black Sea in the Crimean War. Some 89 warships and 300 transports were sent to besiege the Russian naval base at Sevastopol.

NAVIES PLAYED A MARGINAL ROLE in European warfare for most of the 19th century, and sea battles were few. In the Crimean War of 1854–56 sea power was essential in enabling Britain and France to install armies in the Black Sea, but the Russian navy refused to come out and fight. The battle of Lissa in 1866 was fascinating as a ramming combat between ironclads, but irrelevant to the outcome of the war between Austria and Italy. In the Franco-Prussian War of 1870–71 French naval superiority was impotent to offset the dominance of the Prussian army. Yet navies were central to European states' view of themselves as great powers and competition between nations provided the impetus for rapid innovation in warship design and naval armament. When new countries wanted to assert their status—Italy, unified in the 1860s, and Imperial Germany after 1871—they inevitably built fleets.

BRITISH PREDOMINANCE

Britain's Royal Navy enjoyed an overwhelming dominance at sea, but the British nonetheless had to respond to developments in naval technology if they were to stay ahead. In the mid-19th century the transition from wood and sail to steam and steel brought a period of experimentation as designers and strategists juggled with the new technological possibilities. Emperor Napoleon III's France at first led the way with the construction of the battleship *Gloire* in 1859, the first ocean-going ironclad warship, sparking a brief naval race with the British—a race Britain's industrial superiority ensured she would easily win. The success of the *Monitor* in the American Civil War put European navies in a flurry in the 1860s and led to a brief fashion for ramming as a style of combat. Gunports and broadsides were gradually supplanted by turret guns, and sails were somewhat reluctantly abandoned—the Royal Navy battleship *Devastation* launched in 1871 was the first all-steam capital ship.

By the 1880s warship design was settling down, but an arms race between the major European powers was beginning. Fear of the

The power of naval guns
With their powerful long-range guns, warships were often used to bombard targets on shore. Here, the British paddle sloop *Bulldog* joins in the attack on the Russian fort at Bomarsund in the Baltic during the Crimean War.

